



POINT TO PROVE

Both Deiveson Figueiredo and Cory Sandhagen will be looking to **re-establish** themselves as bantamweight title contenders after facing roadblocks in their previous bouts.

Pics: GETTY IMAGES

Nigamanth P

nigamanth.p@thehindu.co.in

Former featherweight champion Deiveson Figueiredo (**below**) and former bantamweight title contender Cory Sandhagen (**above**) will face each other on May 4 in the Ultimate Fighting Championship (UFC).

Both fighters will be looking to re-establish themselves as bantamweight title contenders after facing roadblocks in their previous bouts. Figueiredo suffered a gruelling five-round unanimous decision loss to Petr Yan in a main event back in November last year. Meanwhile, Russia's rising superstar Umar Nurmagomedov made light work of Sandhagen at UFC Fight Night in August.

After conceding the flyweight belt to Brandon Moreno in January 2023, Figueiredo moved up to bantamweight. His transition to the new weight class was seamless, as he secured a unanimous decision win over the experienced Rob Font. The Brazilian topped it off with a submission victory and another decision win in consecutive fights.

This bout presents a high-stakes scenario. For Figueiredo, a win over a top-five bantamweight would

immediately solidify his position as a serious title threat in his new division. For Sandhagen, victory is crucial to regain momentum after his recent loss to Nurmagomedov and to prove that he has what it takes to earn a title shot.

Volkanovski reclaims his throne

Alexander Volkanovski successfully reclaimed the UFC featherweight title at UFC 314, defeating Diego Lopes via unanimous decision (48-47, 49-46, 49-46) on April 12. The victory marked Volkanovski's second reign as featherweight champion, a testament to his resilience after losing the belt to Ilia Topuria earlier in 2024.

The fight itself was a compelling 25-minute affair. Volkanovski started strongly, utilising his experience and technical striking to control the early rounds.

However, Lopes, known for his aggressive style and dangerous submission game, came back strongly in the later rounds, particularly the fourth, where he hurt Volkanovski with

an uppercut and applied relentless pressure.

Despite Lopes's surge, Volkanovski relied on his movement, jab, and composure to weather the storm to secure the decision.

The dominant win was significant for Volkanovski, as he became only the second fighter in UFC history to hold the featherweight title twice, after Jose Aldo. Furthermore, at 36 years old, he became the first fighter over 35 to win a title in the lighter weight classes.

For Diego Lopes, despite the defeat, his performance against a seasoned champion demonstrated his potential as a top contender in the featherweight division. The bout was awarded 'Fight of the Night' for its thrilling back-and-forth action.

In the co-main event, Paddy Pimblett emerged victorious against Michael Chandler, delivering a dominant performance.

Pimblett's effective combination of striking techniques and grappling skills proved overwhelming for Chandler, as the contest concluded in the third round with a TKO. This victory propelled Pimblett four places up in the lightweight rankings, and he now sits in eighth place.

